

Fuelled by an exponentially growing semiconductor industry, commercially available computing power has dramatically increased over the past decade. With the growing commercialisation of sport, people's obsessive need to quantitatively deconstruct everything in sight resulted in increasingly obscure statistics being recorded and scrutinised. As a result, the statistical analytics domain has extended its purview to the world of sport, and for the most part, it has revolutionised sport as we know it.



The Moneyball theory made data analytics in sports mainstream.

At the end of the 2002 season, American Major League Baseball team Oakland Athletics were in trouble. They were on a limited budget compared to the bigger teams in the league, and several important players were about to leave at the end of the season. Desperate to stay competitive, general manager Billy Beane teamed up with Paul DePodesta – a Harvard economics graduate and baseball scout who was heavily reliant on statistical analysis. They found that most teams paid huge salaries to players scoring high on “old-school” baseball stats such as batting averages and total runs, but that those weren’t good indicators of success. However, the “on-base percentage” (OBP) of a player was extremely underrated as a metric, and it turned out that it predicted the success of a player far better. Recruiting players based on OBP numbers turned out to be a stroke of genius – it gave them players who performed well, but whose market value was very low – as they reached the playoffs the next season.

That fateful season inspired the 2003 Michael Lewis book ‘Moneyball’ and the 2011 movie of the same name. More importantly, it changed the way the American baseball league – and eventually the world – analysed sports. There are a few lessons to be learnt from the Moneyball episode. First, identifying statistically significant factors for a team’s success can give you a clear advantage. But second, and more importantly, this advantage does not last long. Sports is commercialised, and that brings with it the fundamentals of capitalism. Rivals soon picked up on the improved scouting